SCAM SHIELD

# Family Scam Safety Kit

Print it, put it on the fridge, and go through it with the people you love. Fifteen minutes now can save thousands later.

- The fridge sheet: Stop. Check. Call.
- 12 red flags that cover almost every scam
- Wallet cards for parents and grandparents
- What to say when a scammer calls
- Your family safe word plan
- The 30-minute account lockdown
- "I think I've been scammed": the first hour

# Stop. Check. Call.

Put this page on the fridge.

## STOP

Any message that rushes you, scares you, or excites you gets a pause. Real problems can wait 10 minutes.

## CHECK

Don't use the link or number in the message. Open the official app, or type the website yourself.

## CALL

Call someone you trust before you pay or share anything. Use the number on your card or bill.

## 12 red flags

- **Pay with gift cards, crypto, wire or Zelle.** No real company or agency asks for this.
- **"Read me the code we just sent you."** That code unlocks your account. Never share it.
- **A deadline in hours.** "Pay within 24 hours or..." is pressure, not policy.
- **Threats.** Arrest, deportation, a frozen account, a suspended Social Security number.
- **"Keep this between us."** Being told not to tell your bank or family.
- **A prize you never entered.** Especially one with a fee to claim it.
- **A link that's almost right.** usps-help.top, paypa1.com, amazon.account-check.xyz.
- **Move money to "keep it safe".** Banks never ask you to move money to protect it.
- **Install AnyDesk or TeamViewer.** Remote access lets them into your bank.
- **A friendly wrong number.** That turns into talk of crypto or investing.
- **A job that pays for "likes" or tasks.** And later asks you to deposit money.
- **A family emergency, by phone or text.** "Grandma, I'm in jail, don't tell Mom." Voices can be faked with AI.

**Not sure?** Paste the message into the free checker at **scamshield.netlify.app**. It runs on your device and nothing is uploaded.

# Wallet cards

Cut along the dashed lines. Give one to each family member, especially parents and grandparents.

### Before I pay anyone

1. Did **I** start this contact?
2. Are they asking for gift cards, crypto, a wire or Zelle?
3. Am I being rushed or told to keep it secret?
4. Have I called someone on this card?

**Any "yes" to 2 or 3? Hang up.**

### People I call first

Name: _____

Phone: _____

Name: _____

Phone: _____

Our family safe word is kept separately, never written on this card.

### Never share

1. Codes texted to you ("one-time code")
2. Your passwords or PIN
3. Your full Social Security number
4. Remote access to your computer

No real bank, agency or tech company asks for these.

### Real numbers only

Bank: number on the back of your card

IRS: irs.gov · Social Security: 1-800-772-1213

Medicare: 1-800-633-4227

Report scam texts: forward to **7726**

Report fraud: ReportFraud.ftc.gov


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# What to say when a scammer calls

You don't owe a caller anything, including politeness. These lines end the call without arguing.

### "This is your bank's fraud department."

> *"We've seen suspicious activity. To protect your money we need you to move it to a secure account / read us the code we sent."*
>
> **"I'll call the number on the back of my card." Then hang up and do it.**

### "This is the IRS / Social Security / the police."

> *"There's a warrant for your arrest. Pay today with gift cards to resolve it."*
>
> **"Send me a letter." Then hang up. Agencies contact you by mail first and never demand gift cards or crypto.**

### "Grandma, it's me. I'm in trouble."

> *"I was in an accident / I'm in jail. Please don't tell Mom. My lawyer will tell you how to send bail."*
>
> **"What's our family safe word?" Then hang up and call your grandchild or their parents on the number you already have.**

### "Microsoft / Apple / Geek Squad here. Your computer is infected."

> *"Install this app so we can fix it / process your refund."*
>
> **"No thanks." Hang up. Never install remote-access apps for someone who contacted you.**

### "I'm a buyer from Marketplace. I sent you a code to prove you're real."

> *"Can you send me the code?"*
>
> **"No, let's keep it on Marketplace." Never forward a code.**

A simple rule for everyone: **if they called you, you call them back** on a number you find yourself.

# Your family safe word

AI tools can copy a voice from a few seconds of video. The FBI suggests families agree on a secret word or phrase to check a caller is really who they say. Set yours up together, today.

- [ ] Pick a word or short phrase that isn't online anywhere: not a pet's name, street, team, or anything in your social media.
- [ ] Tell it only in person. Don't text it, email it, or write it on the wallet card.
- [ ] Agree on the rule: **no word, no money**, however real the voice sounds or however urgent it is.
- [ ] Agree who to call to double-check (for example, the parent of the grandchild).
- [ ] Practise once: one person makes a pretend "emergency" call, the other asks for the word.
- [ ] Change it if it's ever used in front of someone outside the family.

## Talk it through

Ten minutes at the next family dinner covers it. Questions to ask each other:

- [ ] Have you had a strange call or text this year? What did it want?
- [ ] Which payment apps do you use (Zelle, Venmo, Cash App)? Who can see them?
- [ ] Who would you call before sending money in a hurry?
- [ ] Do you know how to forward a scam text to 7726?



Source: FBI IC3 public service announcement on AI-enabled fraud (Dec 2024)

# The 30-minute account lockdown

Do this once for each adult in the family. Tick as you go.

### Credit (10 min)

- [ ] Freeze credit at Equifax (equifax.com)
- [ ] Freeze credit at Experian (experian.com)
- [ ] Freeze credit at TransUnion (transunion.com)
- [ ] Freezes are free and you can lift them in minutes when you need credit.
- [ ] Check your free reports at AnnualCreditReport.com

### Phone (5 min)

- [ ] Add a number-transfer (port-out) PIN or lock with your mobile carrier
- [ ] Turn on your phone's built-in spam call and text filtering
- [ ] Keep the phone's software up to date

### Email and banking (15 min)

- [ ] Turn on two-step login for email first (it resets everything else)
- [ ] Turn on two-step login for your bank and payment apps
- [ ] Turn on transaction alerts for every card and account
- [ ] Use a password manager so every password is different
- [ ] Set payment apps (Zelle, Venmo, Cash App) to private and only pay people you know

### Optional

- [ ] Get an IRS Identity Protection PIN at irs.gov/ippin
- [ ] Create your my Social Security account at ssa.gov so no one else can

# "I think I've been scammed"

**Don't be embarrassed. Act fast.** Scammers are professionals and they target smart people. Money is easier to recover in the first hours.

| If you... | Do this now |
|---|---|
| Paid by card | Call the number on the back of the card. Ask them to dispute the charge and replace the card. |
| Sent a bank transfer, wire or Zelle | Call your bank's fraud line immediately and ask them to recall or reverse the payment. |
| Paid with gift cards | Call the gift card company (number on the back of the card) and tell them it was a scam. Keep the cards and receipts. |
| Sent crypto | Contact the exchange or crypto ATM operator you used and report it. Save the wallet address and transaction ID. |
| Gave a password or code | Change that password now, sign out other devices, and turn on two-step login. |
| Gave your Social Security number | Freeze your credit at all three bureaus and follow the plan at IdentityTheft.gov. |
| Let someone into your computer | Disconnect it from the internet. Change passwords from a different device. Have the computer checked. |

## Then report it

ReportFraud.ftc.gov · IC3.gov (internet crime) · forward texts to 7726 · your local police (you may need a report for your bank)

## Write it down while it's fresh

| | |
|---|---|
| **Date and time** | |
| **How they contacted me** | |
| **Names and numbers they used** | |
| **What I paid, how, and to where** | |
| **Who I've called (and case numbers)** | |

Beware "recovery" scams: anyone who contacts you offering to get your money back for a fee is another scammer.



Educational guide, not legal or financial advice